

US Equity Strategy

Upgrading into uncertainty

Equities remain choppy as peace talks stop and start, and questions linger about AI spend, funding and monetization, higher-for-longer rates, and consumer strength. We focus on the improving earnings outlook, taking our S&P 500 FY26 EPS to \$337 from \$321 and our 2026 PT to 7800 from 7650.

Reprinted from *Upgrading Into Uncertainty: Raise S&P 500 PT to 7800, FY26 EPS to \$337*, 23 June 2026.

- **The macro regime remains complex, but the balance of risks still leans constructive.** Labor data are strong enough to reduce recession risk, but also to push rate cuts further out. Input costs are rising again, though not yet a growth shock large enough to derail the cycle. The equity bull case remains intact, but earnings and AI capex visibility must do more of the work as Fed support fades and positioning is less able to absorb disappointment.
- **We raise our FY26 S&P 500 EPS estimate to \$337 from \$321**, modestly below the Street's \$341 and implying ~21% y/y growth from \$279 in FY25. Tech earnings guidance and visibility remain underpinned by expanding AI capex, reflationary pressure should support nominal revenue growth, and the industrial side of the economy looks relatively supportive into 2027, offsetting potential downside to consumer spending. We also introduce our FY27 EPS estimate at \$389 (+15% Y/Y), below the Street's \$398.
- **Our 2026 S&P 500 price target goes to 7800 from 7650.** We trim our valuation assumptions modestly from the previous update (23x FY26 EPS, down from ~24x) to account for uncertainties around the scale, funding and monetization timeline of capex, AI-led dispersion, and higher nominal yields and inflation. This leaves earnings to do the work in raising our price target. We also introduce our 2027 price target at 8800.
- **We go to Neutral on Financials and Healthcare.** Our bull thesis on the Financials sector has not played out, as banks-driven positive earnings revisions were offset by private credit concerns, regulatory risks within payments, and AI disruption. We believe downward EPS revisions for Healthcare have mostly run their course, leaving risk/reward more balanced. **The balance of our sector views remains unchanged: Positive on TMT, Industrials and Utilities, Negative on the Consumer space.**
- **Risks we are watching into the back half of the year include** signs of stress in the AI investment cycle, including the *'what-ifs' we debated last September*: model advancement, availability of power, and funding (*especially as the financing mix grows more complex*). Rates are re-centering as a key risk factor with a new Fed chair taking the reins amid

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resurgent inflation. Finally, we are keeping a close eye on the US consumer, as higher inflation and lower purchasing power have the potential to generate lagged pressures in 2H26.

FIGURE 1. Barclays FY26 and FY27 estimates for the S&P 500

Scenario	Barclays S&P 500 FY 2026 Estimates					Barclays S&P 500 FY 2027 Estimates			
	EPS	Growth (yoy)	PE Multiple	YE Value	Upside / Downside	EPS	Growth (yoy)	PE Multiple	YE Value
Bull Case	\$343	22.9%	24.8x	8500	13.7%	\$397	17.8%	24.2x	9600
Base Case	\$337	20.8%	23.1x	7800	4.4%	\$389	15.4%	22.6x	8800
Bear Case	\$329	17.9%	19.1x	6300	-15.7%	\$380	12.8%	18.7x	7100
Current S&P 500 Price	7,473								

Data as of 22 June 2026.

Source: Barclays Research

2026: The (equity) story so far

US equities entered 2026 with plenty of good news already priced in: global macro was holding together, AI capex was an undeniable tailwind, and market leadership was beginning to broaden beyond mega-cap Tech into cyclicals, small caps and “old economy” beneficiaries of the AI buildout. But **high valuations left a narrower margin for error.** By February, the months-long debate over AI disruption in software had boiled over, leading the industry to give back all of its outperformance vs. SPX since 2022. Concerns over debt-laden software companies spilled over into already-simmering worries about private credit, which then bled into a broader reassessment of long-duration growth at the same time geopolitical risk was moving to the center of the macro debate. The war in the Middle East then sparked a generational oil shock, stoking renewed fears over inflation, central bank reaction functions and global growth. Equity markets had to price not just AI disruption, but also the possibility that the soft-landing narrative was drifting toward something closer to stagflation-lite.

We believed there was value in looking through the noise and focusing on both the underlying strength of the US economy and the improving fundamentals within US equities. Indeed, once ceasefire headlines shrank both the left tail and the immediate geopolitical risk premium, **investors quickly returned to the parts of the market where earnings visibility looked strongest.** Big Tech, Growth and Momentum surged as investors re-engaged with AI- and Tech-exposed names. **A strong 1Q26 earnings season**, with Tech EPS growth sitting at the best levels since 2010 and revisions to full-year EPS hitting record pace, pointed to more fundamental headroom.

Positioning amplified the speed and magnitude of the round trip. Portfolios came into the year very long equities, leaving stocks vulnerable to synchronized de-risking across discretionary and systematic investors as sentiment turned in 1Q26. Long-only managers cut equity exposure to near year-lows and built cash, hedge funds de-grossed, and systematic strategies rapidly cut equity exposure. Clearing the ceasefire overhang saw these exact dynamics play out in reverse: elevated cash provided fuel for redeployment, real money inflows surged, systematic strategies bought the dip, and option flows pointed to upside chasing in single stocks.

As it stands, the S&P 500 is within a few percentage points of its all-time high, set just earlier this month. While neither the software, private credit nor geopolitical and energy shocks have yet been large or persistent enough to overturn our core equity thesis, **new concerns are emerging into the back half of the year** as markets tangle with resurgent inflation, AI capex scales to unprecedented levels, and the Fed's rate path narrows.

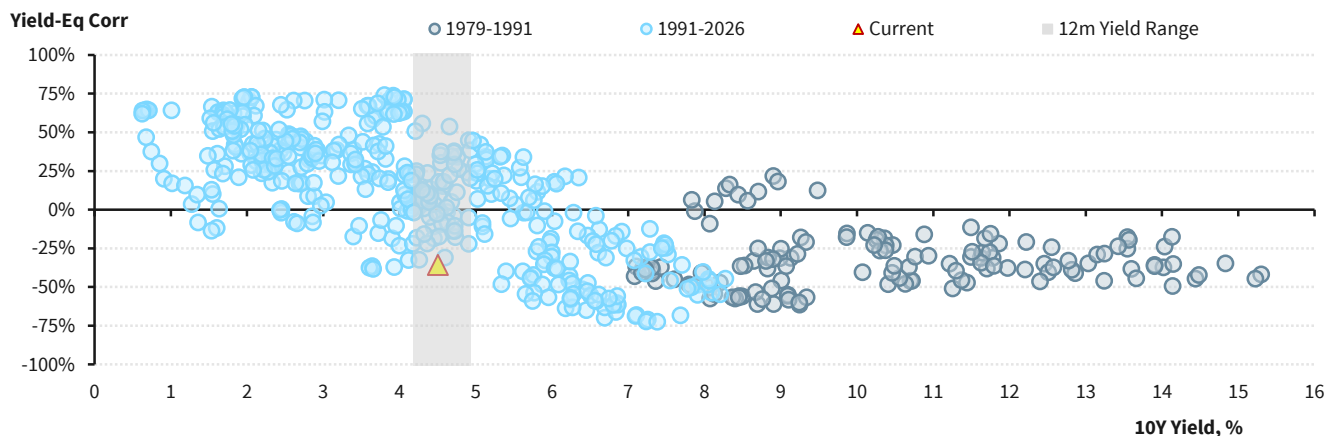
A banner year for earnings, with risks at the margin

The earnings growth engine is firing on all cylinders. Activity data remain constructive: industrial production is on the rise, ISM manufacturing PMI is finally back in expansionary territory, and both durable goods and S&P Global manufacturing output point to solid momentum. The jobs market looks solid, but not overheating. Hyperscalers are redoubling commitments to AI capex and expanding their financing toolkit to match liabilities and capital commitments, which is lengthening earnings upside visibility for a growing swath of downstream industries. And **AI is not the only source of investment**; the energy infrastructure buildout, rising defense spending and the need to rebuild supply chain resilience could lift investment-to-GDP among advanced economies to levels not seen since the 1990s ([Supersize me: The coming investment cycle](#), 26 March 2026).

To be fair, it is not a clean read all around: **higher rates, slower real income growth, and rising costs all pose risks to consumption.** On the input cost front, our colleagues in commodities argue the market is still underpricing the forward oil strip, expecting crude to still average \$100/barrel this year as inventory buffers continue to erode against still-resilient demand ([Energy Sigma: We have a deal](#), 16 June 2026). Activity, employment and commodity prices all feed the inflation and Fed reaction-function debates, increasingly tilting the narrative toward renewed tightening into year-end.

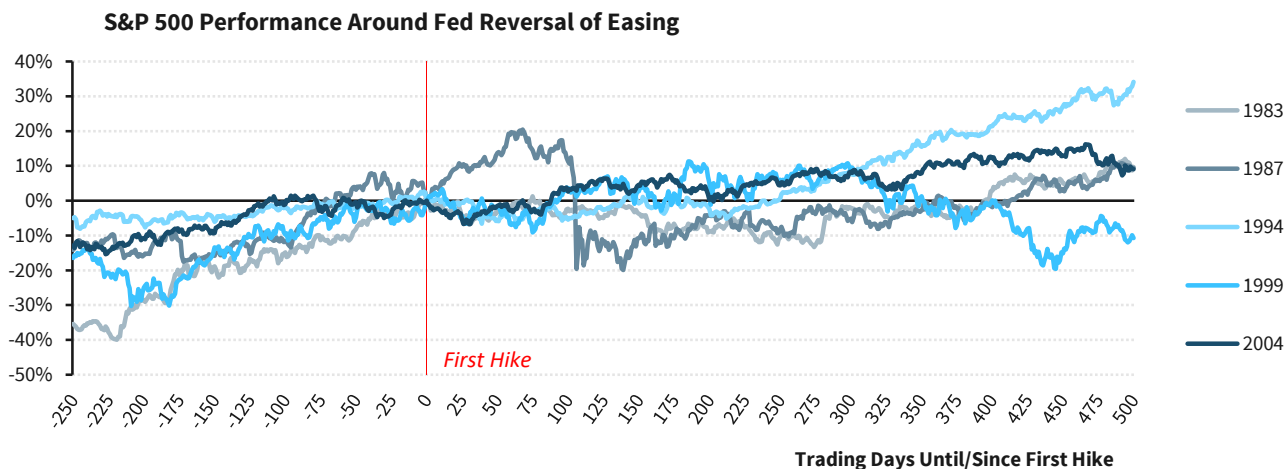
The rebound in equities following the US–Iran détente reinforces the market’s resilience, but we believe yields are re-centering as a key risk factor for equities. The relationship between yields and equities has turned notably negative, suggesting that higher yields are now being read less as a growth signal and more as a constraint on valuations and liquidity. In this regime, incremental increases in either inflation or term premia carry asymmetric downside risk for equities, particularly given the market’s dependence on longer-duration growth assets.

FIGURE 2. The yield-equity correlation is testing the lower bound of its historical range at current levels of the nominal 10y



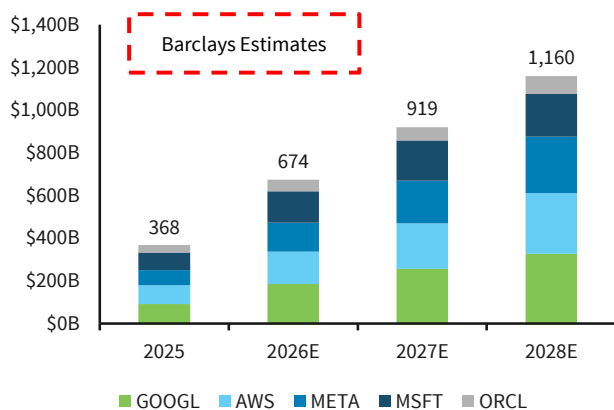
Data as of 22 June 2026. 6m rolling correlations observed at monthly average 10y yields.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

This makes the path of rates especially consequential. Even in an environment of broadly stable growth, upside surprises in inflation could challenge the durability of the recent rally if it leads to a durable repricing of the policy path. Markets are already assigning some probability to additional Fed tightening by year-end, at odds with our more benign baseline expectations for policy. **While the historical record surrounding Fed "reversal of easing" suggests that the mere prospect of the Fed's resuming hikes has not typically derailed equities ahead of the event, the weeks and months following the event could be a different story.**

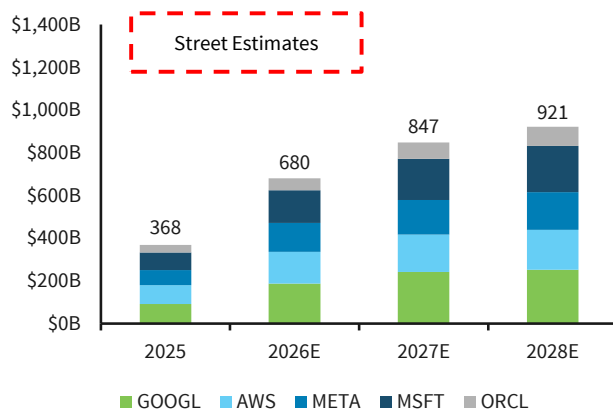
FIGURE 3. The prospect of resumed hikes has not typically derailed equities ahead of the event

The Fed did not announce targeted rate changes prior to 1994. For 1983 and 1987, we anchor dates to Fed meetings immediately preceding rates tightening.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

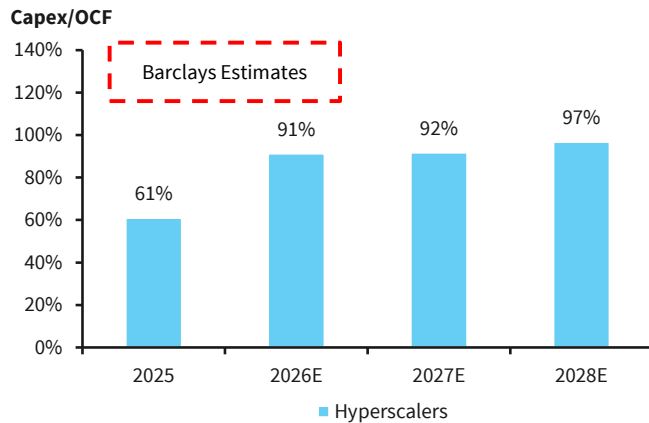
In addition, **AI capex continues to pose its own risks**. While boosting EPS growth now, it also raises execution risks later. We believe "peak capex" has been deferred further out, reflecting both persistent supply constraints in training compute capacity and a material steepening of the demand curve as enterprise adoption accelerates and model improvements unlock new use cases. Hyperscalers are responding with sustained growth in investment over a longer horizon. The result is a **growing mismatch between internally generated cash flow and projected capital requirements**, as our Internet & Semis research teams point out in [AI's S-Curve is Steepening](#) (1 June 2026).

FIGURE 4. Barclays now sees north of ~\$1.1trn in 2028 total hyperscaler capex post-1Q results...

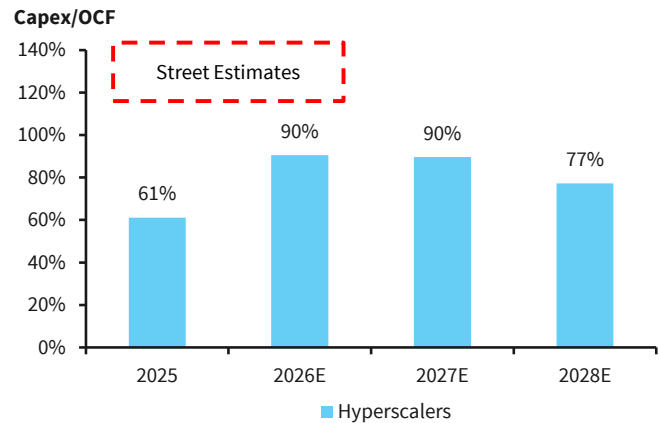
From [AI's S-Curve Is Steepening](#) (1 June 2026).
Source: Company disclosures, Barclays Research

FIGURE 5. ...which is ~26% above the Street....

From [AI's S-Curve Is Steepening](#) (1 June 2026).
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 6. ...driving operating cash flow pressure that we expect to intensify into 2028...

Estimates from Barclays' Internet research team. Note that for AMZN, capex is AWS only, while OCF is total AMZN.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 7. ...which is not baked into consensus estimates

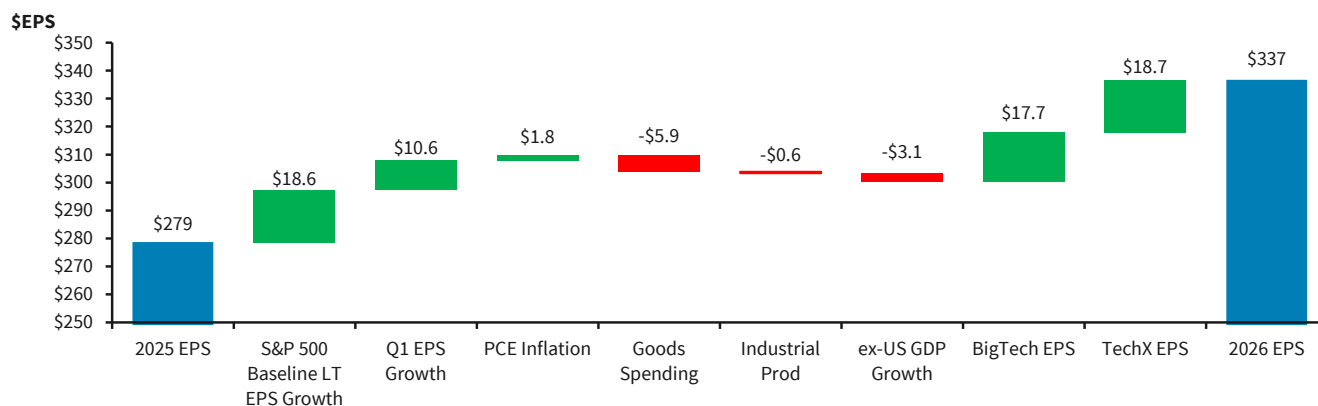
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Overall, **while it is clear that the macro regime remains complex, we believe the balance of risks still leans constructive.** Labor data are strong enough to reduce recession risk, but also to push rate cuts further out. Input costs are rising again, though not yet a growth shock large enough to derail the cycle. The equity bull case remains intact, but earnings and AI capex visibility must do more of the work as Fed support fades and positioning is less able to absorb disappointment.

Raise FY26 EPS estimate to \$337 from \$321

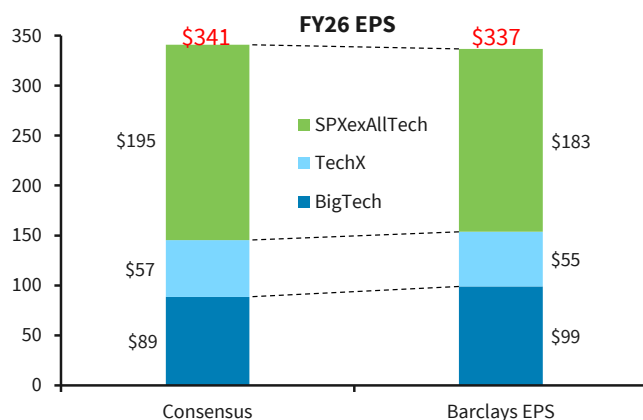
We raise our FY26 S&P 500 EPS estimate to \$337 from \$321, modestly below the Street's \$341 and implying 20.8% y/y growth from \$279 in FY25. Since our previous update, **three developments argue for a higher EPS estimate:** 1) 1Q26 earnings season was materially stronger than expected, confirming that Big Tech and the rest of TMT continue to convert AI-related demand into earnings upside, and upward revisions to the full-year consensus are running well ahead of average; 2) reflationary pressure through 2026 should support nominal revenue growth, particularly in sectors with operating leverage or commodity exposure; and 3) the industrial side of the economy looks relatively supportive into 2027, with our economists' forecasts pointing to a better industrial production backdrop next year. **We expect these upside drivers to be modestly offset by weaker consumption:** spending data have cooled and real purchasing power gains look more modest at current inflation.

Around our base case of \$337, we estimate a relatively tight bull/bear range of \$343/\$329, underscoring that the core debate is less about directional earnings risk and more about the magnitude and persistence of key cyclical drivers. The dispersion is primarily a function of uncertainty about the durability of the Tech beat-and-raise, alongside the trajectory of goods consumption and whether recent resilience can be sustained into a softer macro backdrop. Industrial activity represents a second-order swing factor, particularly given its sensitivity to both global demand and inventory dynamics, while the path of inflation also remains critical.

FIGURE 8. Q1 beat-and-raise, secular growth and nominal pricing power to underpin FY26 EPS growth

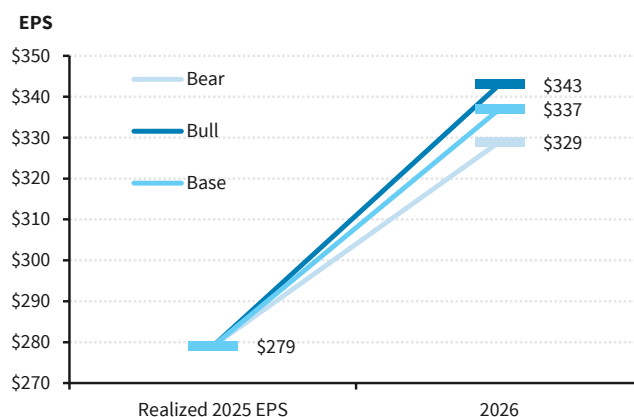
Data as of 10 June 2026.

Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 9. We estimate \$337 in FY26 EPS (+21% y/y) vs. the Street at \$341

Data as of 16 Jun 2026

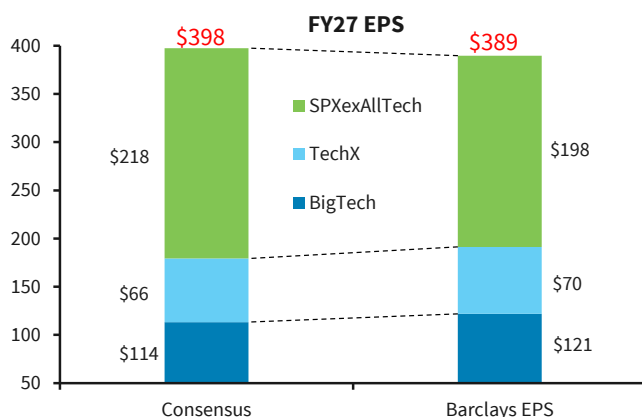
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 10. FY26 Base, Bull and Bear case EPS scenarios

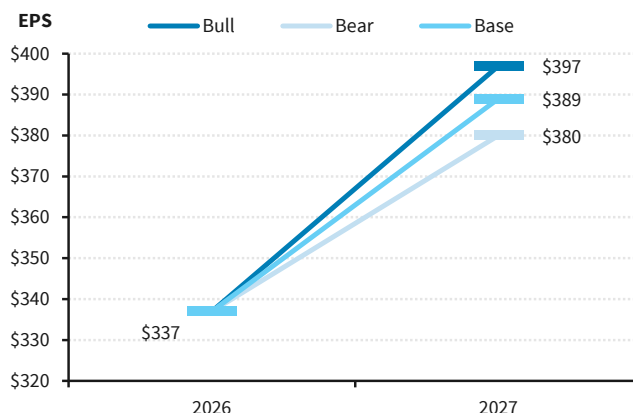
Data as of 10 Jun 2026

Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

We introduce a preliminary FY27 EPS estimate of \$389, reflecting a modest deceleration in growth. Our framework assumes a partial recovery in consumption on y/y basis, coupled with continued strength in industrial production as the lagged effects of prior tightening fade. This is partially offset by a normalization in nominal pricing power, particularly as disinflationary forces broaden. The resulting bull and bear cases of \$397/\$380 capture a similar set of crosscurrents, with upside tied to a more durable demand recovery and sustained Tech momentum, while downside reflects the risk of a more protracted normalization in margins and growth.

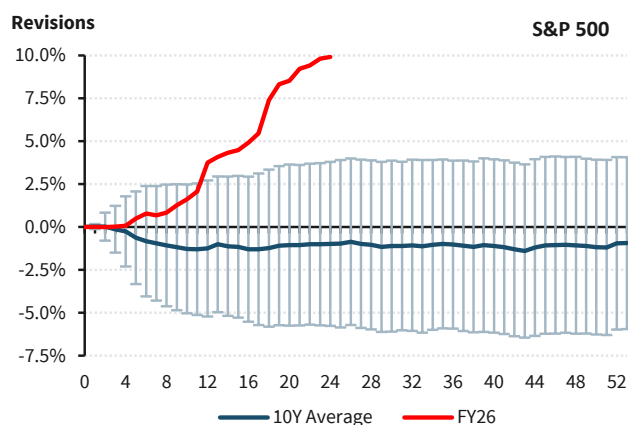
FIGURE 11. We estimate \$389 in FY27 EPS (+15% y/y) vs. Street at \$398

Data as of 10 Jun 2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

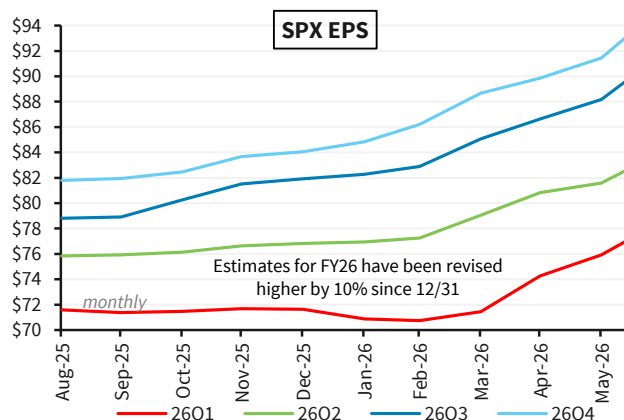
FIGURE 12. FY27 Base, Bull and Bear case EPS scenarios

Data as of 10 Jun 2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

We recognize that a central pillar of our EPS framework rests on the view that Tech can continue to deliver positive earnings upside even as consensus estimates and revisions already sit at elevated levels vs. history. Skepticism about the magnitude and durability of this outperformance is understandable, particularly given **concerns about where we are in the AI investment cycle and whether current growth assumptions embed an implicit peak**. Still, our industry analyst colleagues see good reason to believe that much of the supply-demand imbalance in AI compute will persist well into CY27 ([Making the Case for Another Leg Higher in the Memory Trade](#), 26 May 2026), and we think this visibility provides a degree of near-term de-risking to NTM estimates. While we do not dismiss the possibility of normalization further out, current conditions argue that earnings estimates for Tech over the near term are not overly heroic.

FIGURE 13. YTD revisions to full-year EPS are running well ahead of 10-year norms...

Data as of 16 June 2026. 10y average from 2014-2025, excluding 2020 and 2021.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

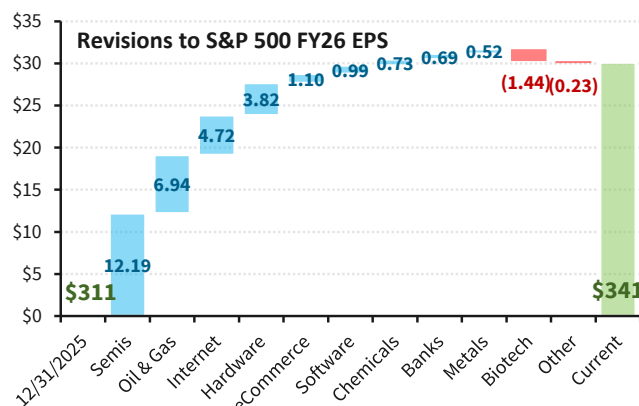
FIGURE 14. ...with all quarters seeing a pickup in EPS estimates since the end of calendar 1Q26

Data as of 16 Jun 2026.
Source: Bloomberg, LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

FIGURE 15. FY26 EPS growth estimates for Tech industries, YE25 vs. today

FY26 EPS Growth Estimates	12/31/2025	Today
Semiconductor and Semiconductor Equipment	66%	127%
Technology Hardware, Storage & Peripherals	14%	39%
Software	18%	13%
Communications Equipment	14%	14%
IT Services	16%	4%
Electronic Equipment and Components	30%	33%

Data as of 13 Jun 2026
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 16. Semis and IT Hardware account for more than half of the + \$31 added to FY26 Street estimates YTD

Data as of 16 Jun 2026
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

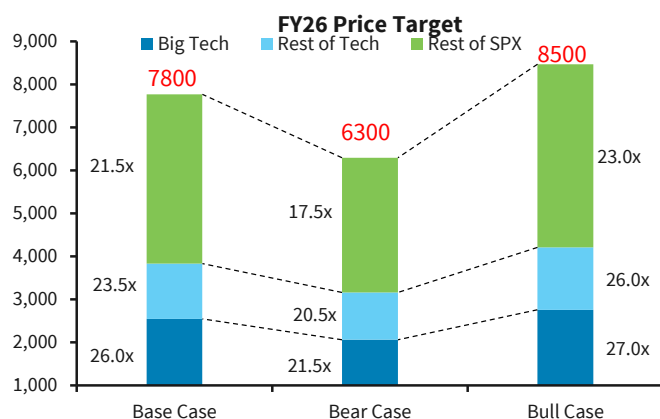
Raise 2026 price target to 7800 from 7650

Our SOTP valuation framework assigns Big Tech a lower baseline multiple than in March (26x vs. 27.5x). We continue to believe the group offers durable earnings growth, but we trim our valuation assumptions to account for uncertainties about the scale, funding and monetization timeline of the AI infrastructure buildout. **We also trim our baseline multiple assumption for the rest of the Tech sector to 23.5x from 25.0x.** While data center capex and AI adoption are broadening, valuation dispersion is increasing as investors look to separate AI winners from losers within the broader Tech space.

For the rest of the S&P 500, we derive a fair value P/E of 21.5x based on 10, Treasury yields, trimmed PCE inflation, and manufacturing PMI. These macro inputs are less supportive than at the start of the year, but not weak enough to warrant a material de-rating. Nominal yields have remained relatively contained since March, and [our rates colleagues continue to frame the Fed's reaction function as patient, rather than signaling a return to aggressive tightening](#). At the same time, manufacturing activity and nominal growth indicators remain firm enough to support earnings, while still-elevated inflation underpins nominal revenue growth.

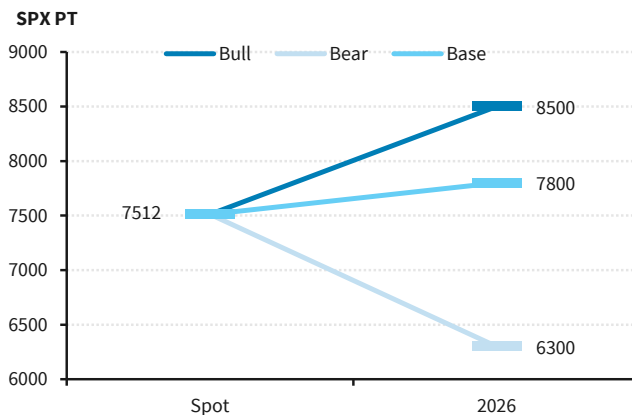
Applying the blended multiple takes our YE26 S&P 500 target up to 7800 from 7650, 23x our \$337 FY26 EPS estimate. Our upwardly revised EPS estimate does the heavy lifting, as our valuation assumptions are reduced modestly from our previous update. Our base case reflects a still-constructive backdrop where AI-driven capex supports earnings resilience, while the broader macro backdrop stays durable in the face of higher-for-longer inflation and rates. Upside to 8500 in our bull case would require a stronger translation of AI investment into productivity and margins, alongside a more benign macro path. Conversely, our 6300 bear case embeds a slowdown in AI capex and tighter financial conditions, driving both EPS and multiple compression risks highlighted in prior work.

FIGURE 17. 2026 S&P 500 price target goes to 7800 from 7650



Data as of 11 Jun 2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

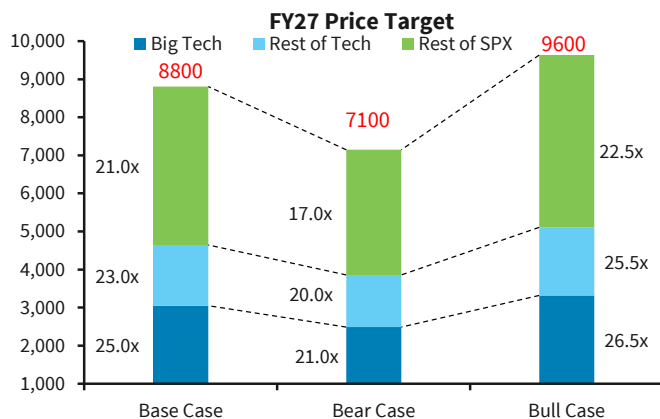
FIGURE 18. 2026 Base, Bull and Bear case PT scenarios



Data as of 16 Jun 2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

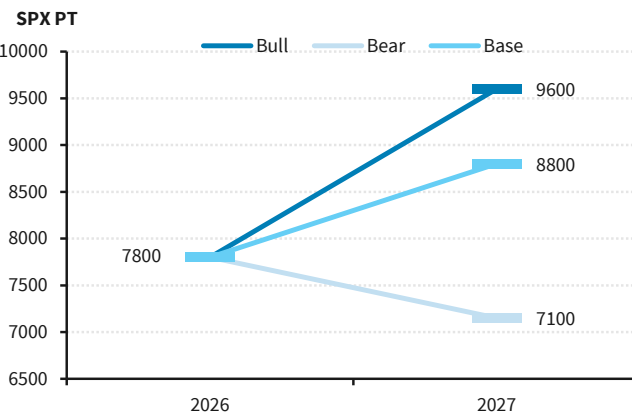
Extending the horizon into 2027, we introduce targets of 8800 in our base case, 9600 in the bull case and 7100 in the bear case, reflecting a more tempered but still constructive long-duration pathway for equities. These estimates are derived by modestly trimming our 2026 multiple assumptions by roughly a half turn across scenarios, acknowledging the effect of a longer discounting period, as well as greater uncertainty about the durability of AI-led earnings expansion, the terminal level of Fed policy rates, and the broader macro equilibrium.

FIGURE 19. We introduce our 2027 preliminary PT at 8800



Data as of 11 Jun 2026
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 20. 2027 Base, Bull and Bear case PT scenarios



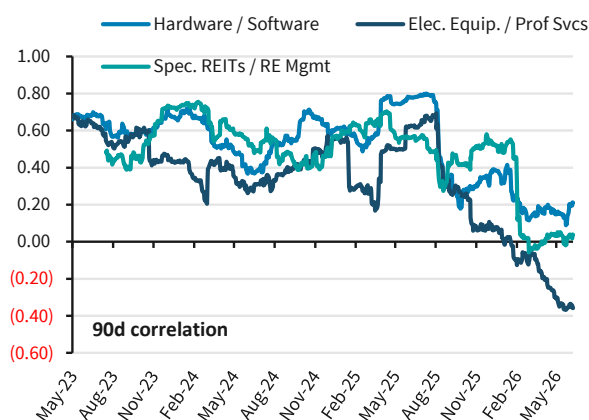
Data as of 11 Jun 2026
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Sector and factor recommendations

As a preamble to our sector views, we'd point out that the evolution of the AI narrative continues to reshape the market structure. **Correlations within sectors have collapsed to historically low levels**, reflecting a market increasingly dominated by idiosyncratic earnings outcomes and positioning, as well as AI disruption narratives. At the same time, concentration in a narrow group of leaders has widened the gap between single-stock and index behavior, with single-stock volatility rising alongside heightened event risk. Together, these dynamics have, we believe, reduced the effectiveness of sectors as an expression of views, reinforcing the

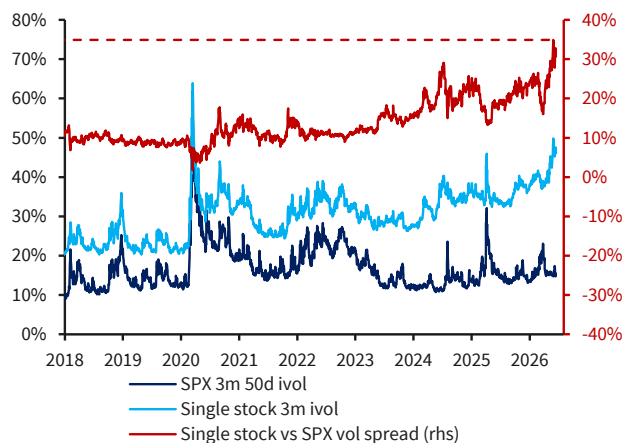
shift toward stock selection and narrow thematic exposure (sub-industries, AI winners & losers, select factors) in a dispersion-rich environment.

FIGURE 21. Correlations collapsing between AI winners/losers



Data as of 18 June 2026.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 22. The single stock vs. index vol spread is elevated compared with history



Data as of 17 June 2026.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Derivatives Research

Against this backdrop, we implement two changes to our sector positioning. First, **we downgrade Financials to Neutral**. While earnings estimate revisions for banks remain constructive (supported by stronger net interest income, resilient loan growth, and improved trading and capital markets activity), the broader sector faces more mixed fundamentals. Regulatory risks from credit card fees and lingering concerns over private credit exposure and AI disruption continue to weigh on non-bank components. As a result, we see modest downside risk to consensus EPS growth expectations at the sector level. Valuations are undemanding, but largely reflect these risks, leaving the overall risk/reward more balanced. Within Financials, we continue to prefer banks, where earnings visibility remains stronger.

Second, **we upgrade Healthcare to Neutral**. Earlier concerns about downside risk to FY26 EPS, driven by difficult comparisons, have partially played out; consensus estimates have been revised materially lower. With expectations now reset, we see only modest additional downside risk. At the same time, the sector trades modestly above its 5y median forward P/E, despite meaningful underperformance YTD. This combination suggests a more balanced setup, where neither valuation nor earnings present a strong directional signal.

The balance of our sector views remain unchanged: Positive on TMT, Industrials and Utilities, Negative on the Consumer space. We provide rationale in the table below.

FIGURE 23. sector views

Sector	View	'26 EPS Δ% (Barclays)	'26 EPS Δ% (Street)	vs. Street	Current Valuation	Rationale
Big Tech	POS	36.10	23.19	12.91	23.9x	We remain Positive on the TMT complex. Big Tech core verticals (digital ads, public cloud) are performing well as the group positions for further AI monetization. Expanding capex boosts EPS for component names across chips, memory & equipment. Overall Tech P/E's remain below 2Y/3Y medians.
Rest of Tech	POS	81.28	69.44	11.84	23.6x	
Communication Services	POS	8.82	12.09	(3.26)	35.6x	
Industrials	POS	12.96	7.30	5.66	25.7x	We see upside to FY26 EPS as PMIs/IP improve. Positioned to benefit from both fiscal spending and AI capex, while relatively insulated from deflation. Valuations elevated but remain off YTD highs.
Utilities	POS	8.81	12.18	(3.37)	17.5x	We see modest downside to Street FY26 EPS but still expect Utilities to be one of the better AI-adjacent earnings growth stories at a reasonable valuation.
Financials	NEU ↓	4.44	7.65	(3.21)	15.5x	Downgrade to Neutral; setup for banks remains favorable but rest of the sector challenged by regulatory risks, private credit and AI disruption.
Real Estate	NEU	3.36	2.79	0.57	28.5x	We see little risk to consensus FY26 earnings growth, but P/FFO multiples look elevated with respect to current nominal Treasury yields.
Energy	NEU	29.19	48.69	(19.50)	6.3x	We believe revisions to FY26 earnings estimates have run too far, too fast even with respect to higher oil prices. But valuations have come in from March peaks and Barclays sees upside to consensus crude forecasts.
Materials	NEU	28.85	39.84	(10.99)	18.0x	Supply-demand imbalance and resource nationalism leave industrial metals looking better positioned than commodity chemicals.
Health Care	NEU ↑	(0.70)	1.13	(1.83)	17.8x	Upgrade to Neutral; downward revisions to FY26 EPS are likely to have mostly run their course, but we expect earnings growth to remain weak vs. tough 2025 comps.
Consumer Staples	NEG	5.58	4.63	0.94	22.1x	We remain Negative on the Consumer complex. While spending data remains resilient, moderating income gains and higher inflation (including gas prices) are likely to create lagged pressure in 2H, leading to a modest consumption slowdown.
Consumer Discretionary	NEG	3.95	4.76	(0.81)	23.0x	

Data as of 16 June 2026. Our sector earnings framework combines bottom-up and top-down approaches, adjusting consensus estimates based on historical bias and macro variables relevant to each sector. EBITDA and EV/EBITDA applied instead of EPS and P/E for Energy; FFO and P/FFO applied for Real Estate. Consumer Discretionary valuation is a simple average of constituent P/E, to adjust for the influence of TSLA. Arrows next to sector views denote changes.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

On factors, we recently downgraded Momentum to Neutral, reflecting historically crowded positioning that creates downside asymmetry despite Momentum's strong NTM earnings growth and reasonable valuations. We remain Positive on Growth and Neutral on Value, underpinned by powerful Tech-led 1Q26 earnings momentum, supportive valuations and AI capex tailwinds within Growth. Our Positive Large-over-Small view is maintained, as small caps remain vulnerable due to weak earnings revisions, near-record negative beta to the 10-year yield, and valuation excesses in segments such as small-cap software, in contrast to mega-cap hyperscalers. We remain Negative on Quality as markets look through geopolitical risks in a risk-on regime, Neutral on High-over-Low Volatility given stretched valuations and AI-linked exposure offset by committed capex and favorable June-July seasonality, and Neutral on Yield as the long/short Yield basket is pressured by AI-driven inflation impulses and flow diversion, though cheap valuations and light positioning limit further downside.

Analyst(s) Certification(s):

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